Everyone Loves Democracy, But Who Wants to Protect it?

Examining Support for Militant Democracy

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Militant democracy: The Debate

Militant democracy: the legal restriction of political rights of actors who seek to undermine or dismantle democratic institutions (Bourne, 2022; Müller, 2016)

Militant democracy: The Debate

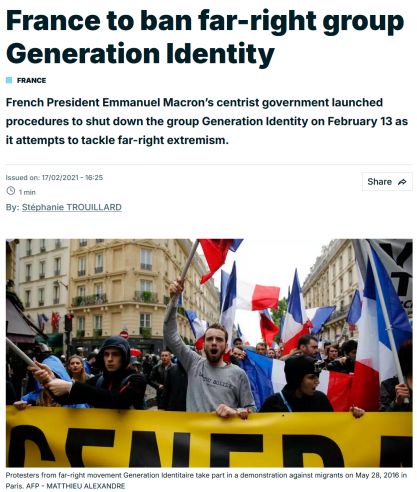
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Militant democracy as self-defence

- Democracy defends itself against undemocratic actors (Müller, 2016)
- Pre-emptive measures: proscription, employment bans, withdrawal public funding, deplatforming, banning candidates (Bourne, 2022; Laumond, 2022)

Militant democracy as autocratic tool?

- Punitive use of measures against political opposition (Olsen & Tuovinen, 2024)



France to ban far-right group Generation Identity

FRANCE

French President Emmanuel Macron's centrist government launched procedures to shut down the group Generation Identity on February 13 as it attempts to tackle far-right extremism.

Issued on: 17/02/2021 - 16:25
1 min
By: Stéphanie TROUILLARD

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Protesters from far-right movement Generation Identitaire take part in a demonstration against migrants on May 28, 2016 in Paris. AFP - MATTHIEU ALEXANDRE



US designates four European anti-fascist groups as terrorist threats

State department claims groups in Germany, Italy and Greece 'conspiring to undermine foundations of western civilization'

Militant democracy: Existing research & Gap

Existing research

- Normative justification (Invernizzi Accetti & Zuckerman, 2017; Müller, 2022; Olsen & Tuovinen, 2024)
- Design & effectiveness of measures (Bourne, 2022; Laumond, 2020; Zeller & Vaughan, 2023)

What do we know less about?

- Attitudes towards militant democracy
- Drivers of support for pre-emptive measures

Why should we care?

- Public support needed for acceptance & legitimacy of measures

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Research Question

What drives support for pre-emptive militant democracy measures against political organisations?

Expectations

H1 **Democracy conceptions:** Individuals are more likely to support pre-emptive measures against organisations in general, if they hold a stronger militant conception of democracy.

- Democracy conceptions shape sanctioning of undemocratic behaviour

(Wunsch et al., 2025)

H2 **Ideological bias:** Individuals are more likely to support pre-emptive measures against organisations that are ideologically distant to them.

- Hypocrisy: opponents' violations sanctioned more than co-partisans'

(Graham & Svolik, 2020; Krishnarajan, 2023; Le Corre Juratic et al., 2025)

H3 **Democratic threat:** Individuals are more likely to support pre-emptive measures against an organisation if it is formally marked as a democratic threat.

- Perceived threat increases openness to rights curtailment

(McCoy et al., 2018; Simonovits et al., 2022)

Expectations

Effect of threat designation (H3) is . . .

H3a . . . stronger for individuals with **higher institutional trust**.

- Domestic intelligencee designations often contested

H3b . . . stronger for individuals with a **more militant conception**.

- Militant citizens respond stronger to signals of democratic threat

H3c . . . weakest for individuals **ideologically close** to the organisation.

- People discount threat designations of co-partisans (Krishnarajan, 2023)

H3d Interaction between threat designation and democratic militancy **strongest at moderate ideological distance**.

- Partisan motivation weakest without closeness nor hostility

H4 . . . stronger for respondents receiving **militant democracy prime**.

- Priming democratic attitudes can reduce tolerance for backsliding

(Braley et al., 2023; Wuttke & Foos, 2025)

Research design

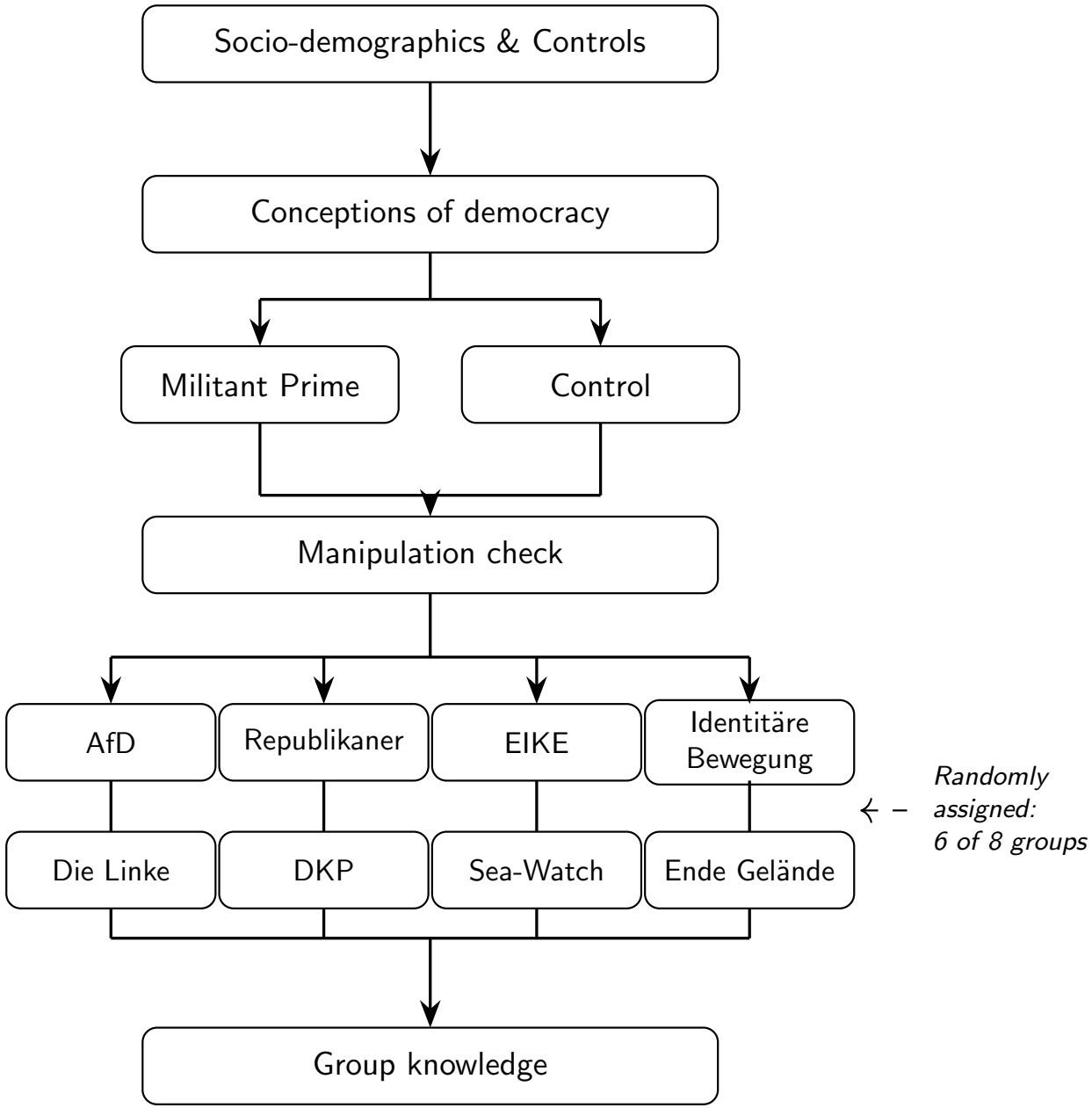
Case: Germany

- Most Likely Case
- Militant democracy strongly institutionalised
- Salient in public debates

Data

- Pre-registered representative survey fielded in February 2026 (4,000 respondents)

Resarch Design



DV: support for pre-emptive measures

Group	Type	Ideology	Threat Assessment
AfD	Party	Right	Threat
Republikaner	Party	Right	No Threat
Identitäre Bewegung	Movement	Right	Threat
EIKE	Movement	Right	No Threat
Die Linke	Party	Left	No Threat
DKP	Party	Left	Threat
Ende Gelände	Movement	Left	Threat
Sea-Watch	Movement	Left	No Threat

Survey items (for each actor):

- [Actor] should be banned.
- [Actor] should not receive public funds or subsidies.
- Members of [Actor] should not be invited on public broadcasting programs.

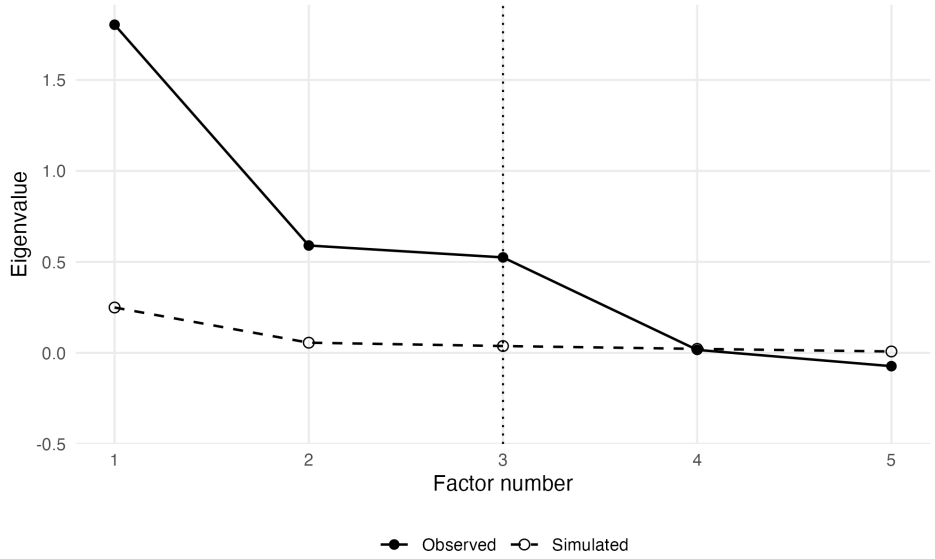
For main models: combined into a factor score

Advantage:

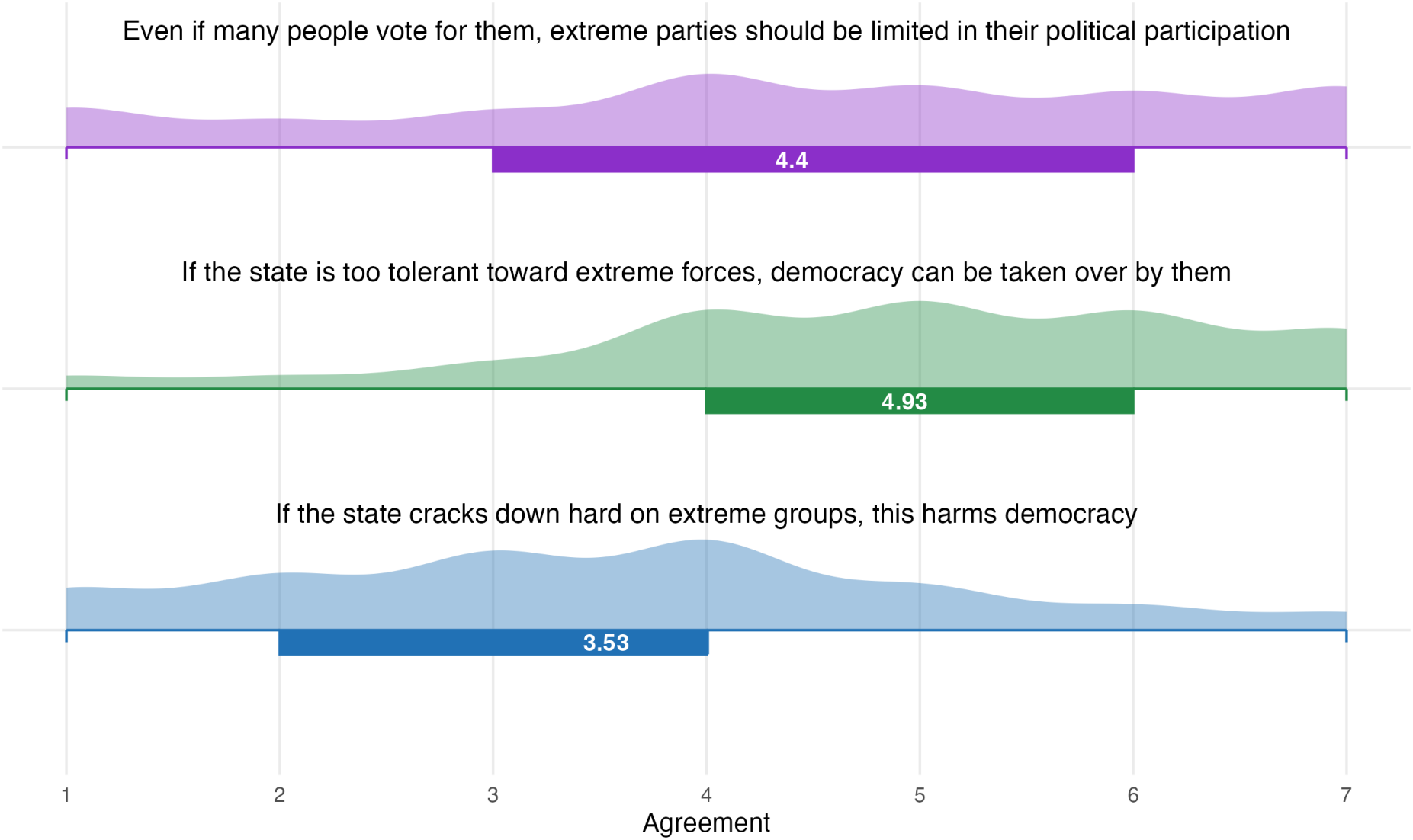
- Broad scope (avoid idiosyncratic results driven by one measure / one actor)
- External Validity (truthful universe of actors)

Militant Democracy Conception

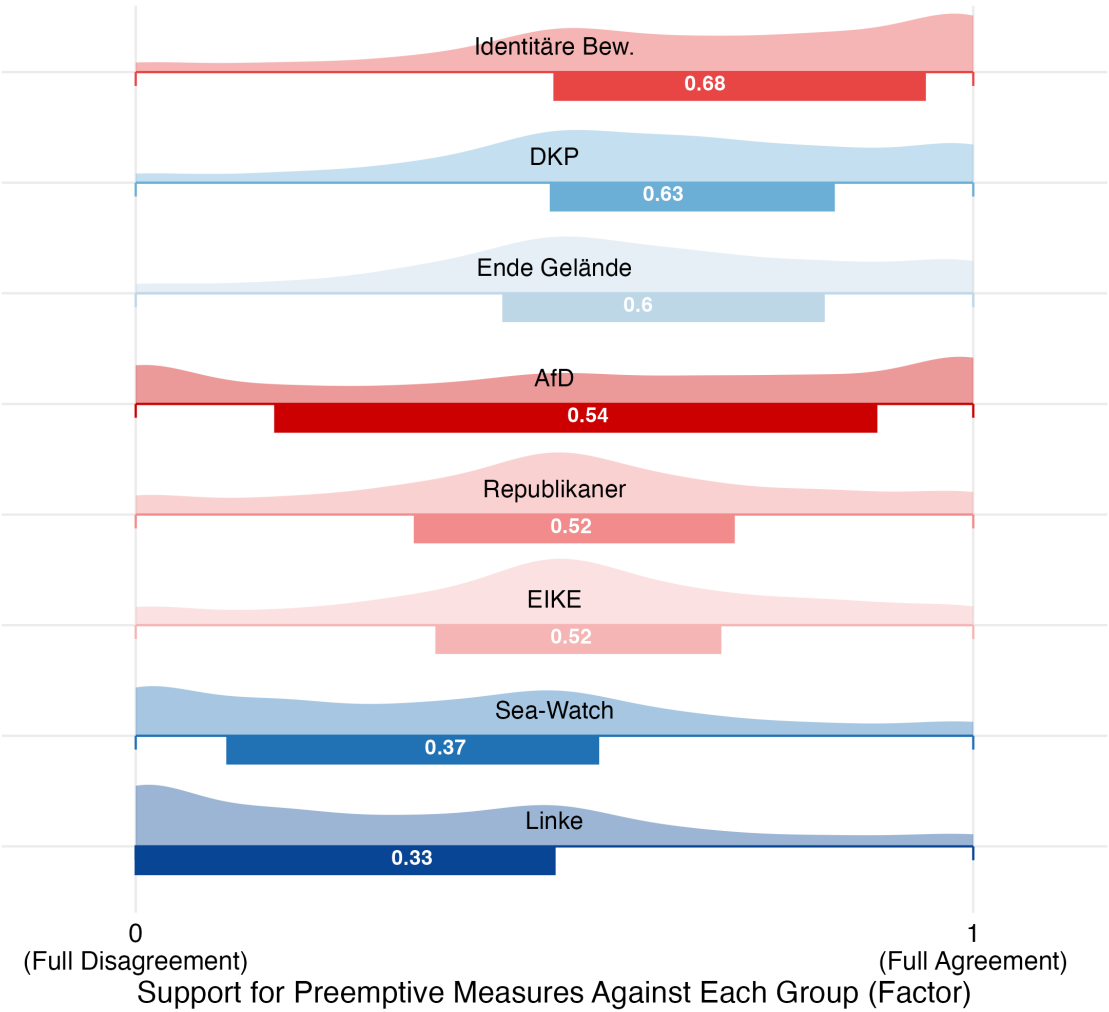
Item	Maj.	Lib.	Mil.
The will of the majority should always take precedence, even over the rights of minorities	0.70		
Courts should not be allowed to overturn majority decisions	0.67		
Politicians should implement the will of the majority, even if they personally disagree	0.50	0.31	
Universal suffrage should be reconsidered, as many voters are poorly informed and easily influenced	0.42		
People who reject my way of life should still have the opportunity to express themselves in public		0.70	
A consolidated democracy should be able to tolerate even extreme opinions		0.56	
Even if many people vote for them, extreme parties should be limited in their political participation			0.71
If the state is too tolerant toward extreme forces, democracy can be taken over by them			0.62
If the state cracks down hard on extreme groups, this harms democracy			-0.31
Variance Exp.	17%	11%	12%
Cum. Variance Exp.		40%	
RMSEA Index		0.053	



Militant democracy items



Support for Pre-Emptive Measures against Organisations

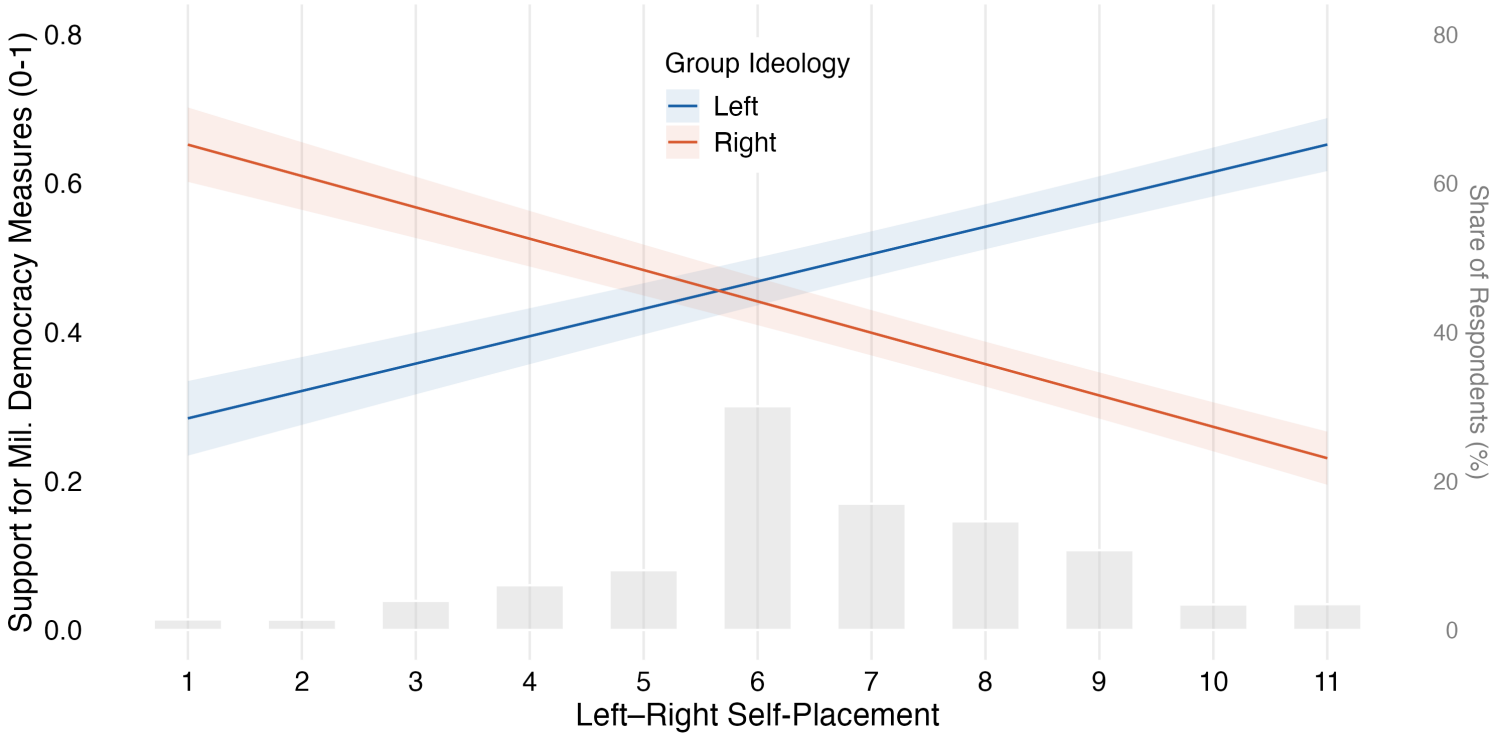


Note: Red = right-leaning; Blue = left-leaning.

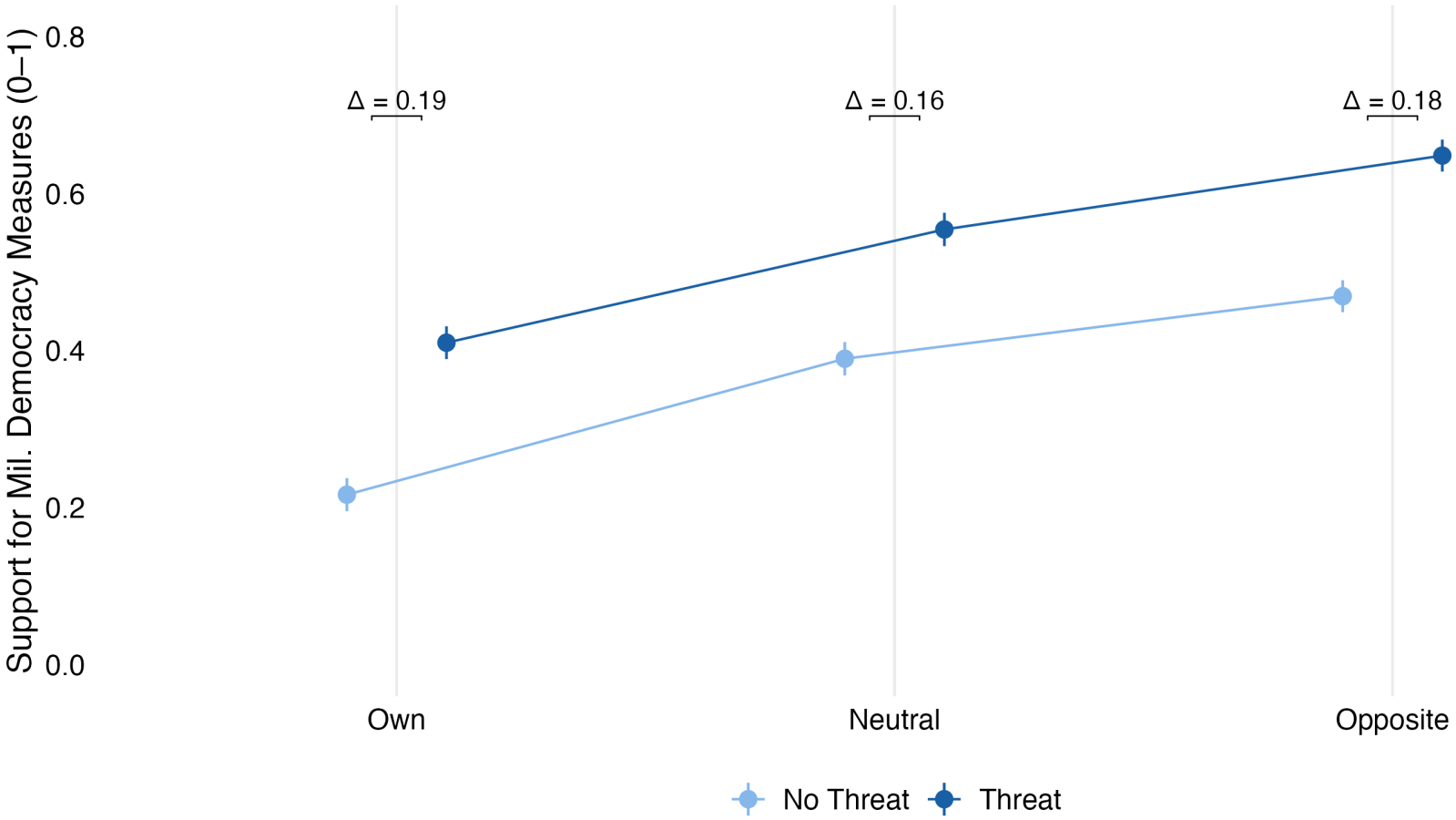
Evidence Regarding Expectations

	Conceptions	Threat Designation			Ideology
Militant Conception (Scaled)	0.07***				
	(0.003)				
Majoritarian Conception (Scaled)	0.03***				
	(0.003)				
Liberal Conception (Scaled)	−0.02***				
	(0.003)				
Threat Designation	0.16***	0.17***	0.17***	0.16***	
	(0.004)	(0.004)	(0.004)	(0.004)	
Threat Designation × Trust Dom. Intelligence Agency			0.11***		
			(0.004)		
Threat Designation × Mil. Conception (Scaled)				0.09***	
				(0.004)	
Group-Ideology: Right					0.63***
					(0.01)
Left-Right Self-Placement					0.05***
					(0.002)
Group: Right × L-R Self-Placement					−0.09***
					(0.002)
maleMale	0.002	−0.01	−0.01	−0.001	−0.01
	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)
Respondent Random Int.	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Socio-Dem. Controls	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Group-Level Controls	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Militancy Treatment	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Constant	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	17,620	20,543	20,242	17,620	20,543

Support for Militant Measures by Group and own Ideology



Threat Designation Effect Based on Ideological Sides



Notes: Δ denotes threat designation effect (i.e. difference in predicted support for militant measures).

Key takeaways and next steps

Takeaways

- Support for pre-emptive measures is shaped by democracy conceptions, democratic threat & ideological bias
- Institutional trust increases acceptance of militant democracy measures!
- Ideological bias may legitimise arbitrary use of restrictions

Next steps

- More Sub-group analyses
- Militancy Prime
- Open-ended question

Thank you!

Questions?

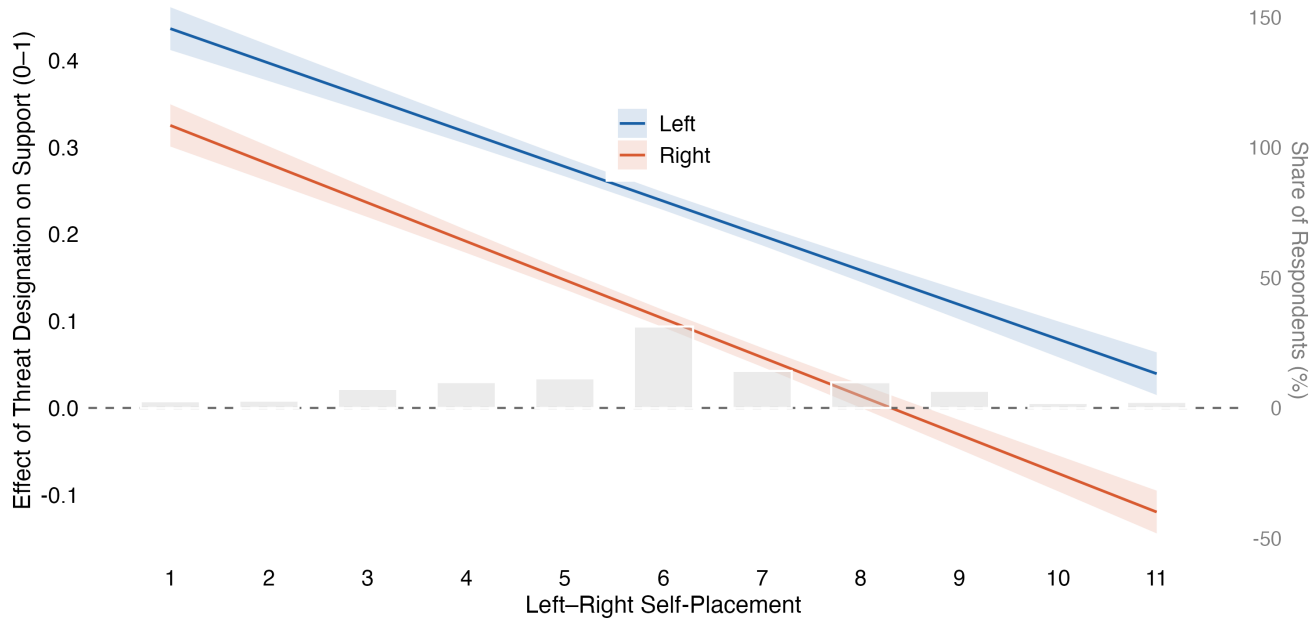
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Survey Design

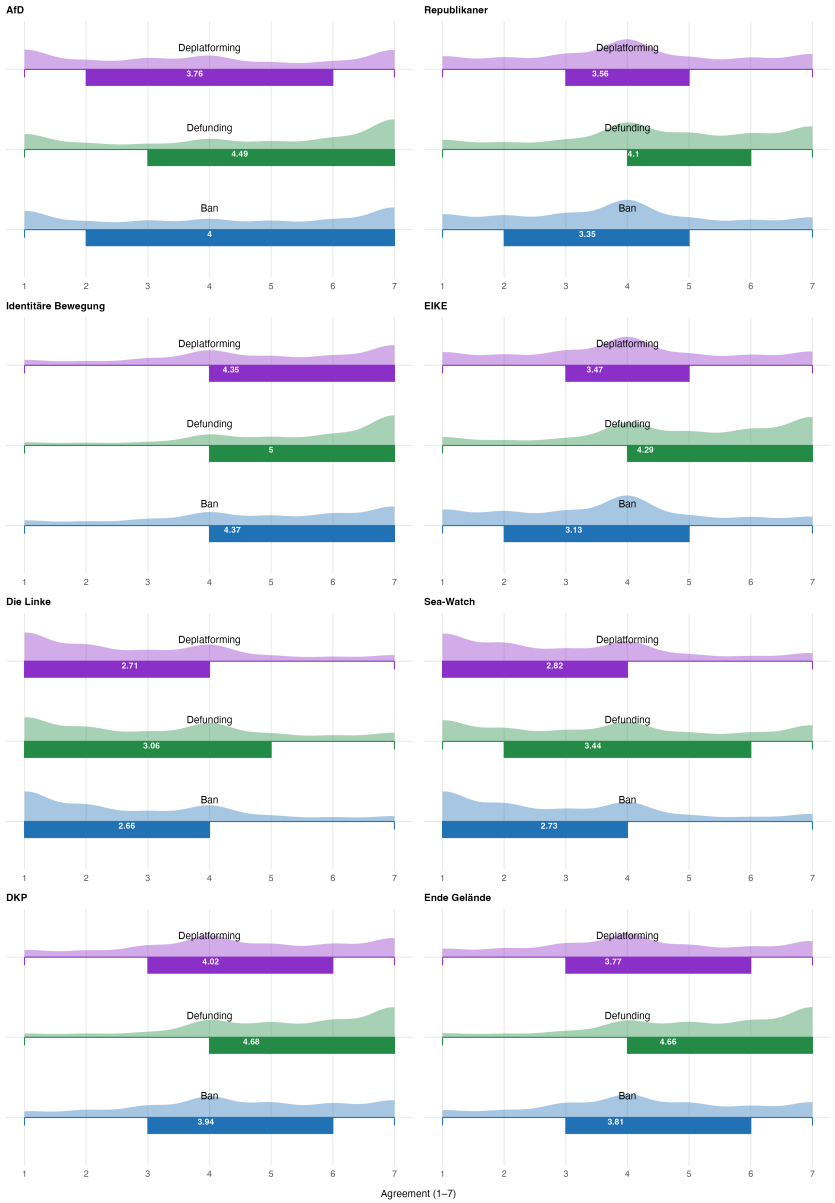
DKP (Deutsche Kommunistische Partei)

The German Communist Party (DKP) is a political party with few members and a low vote share in federal elections. Since 1968, the domestic intelligence agency has classified the DKP as "confirmed left-wing extremist." According to the authorities, core positions of the party violate the free democratic basic order.

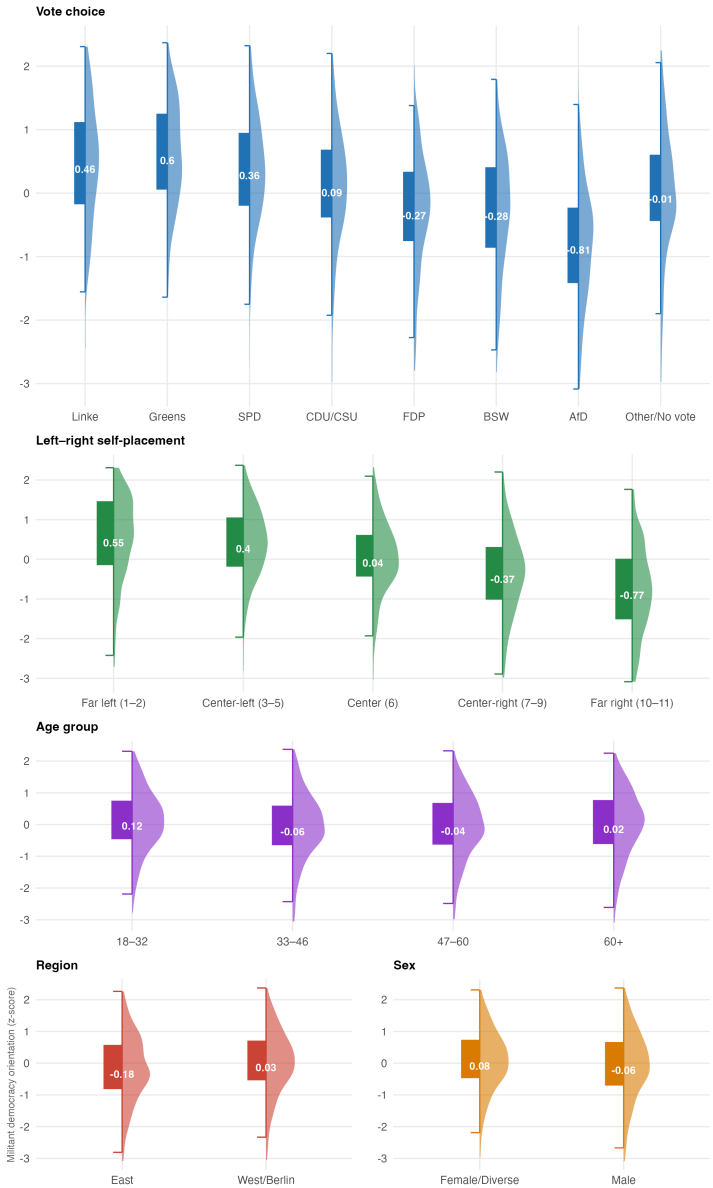
Threat Designations matter mostly for left-leaning respondents



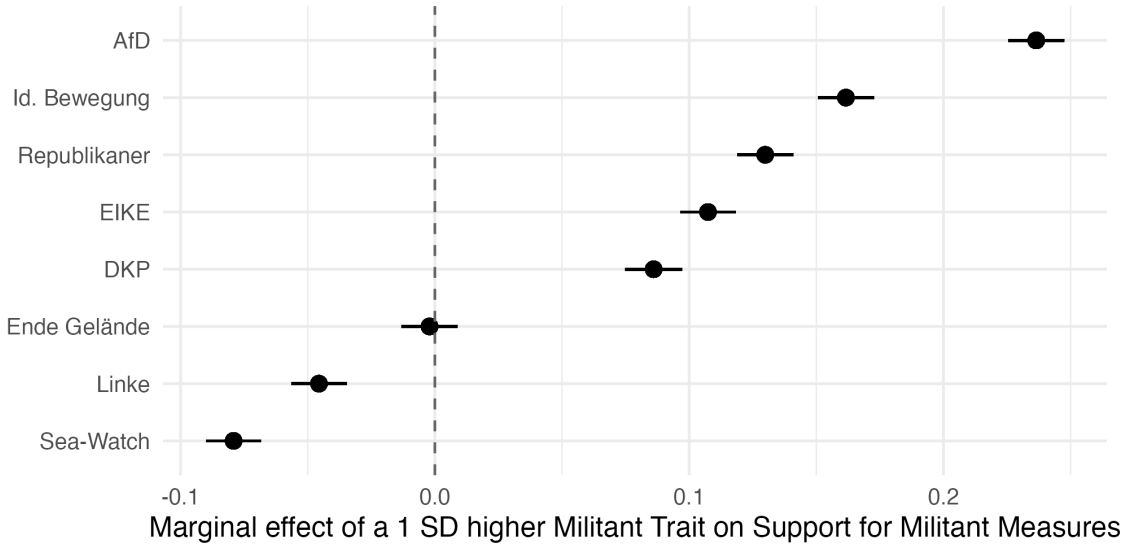
Distributions of Raw Support for Militant Measures



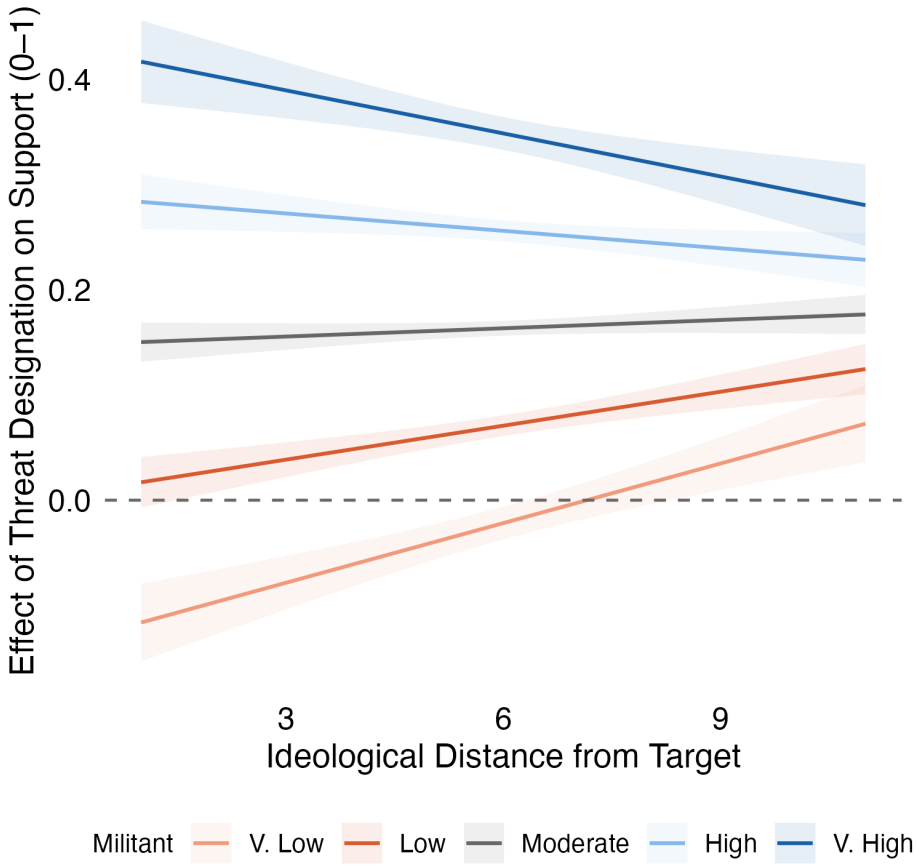
Militant Democratic Conception over Sub-Groups



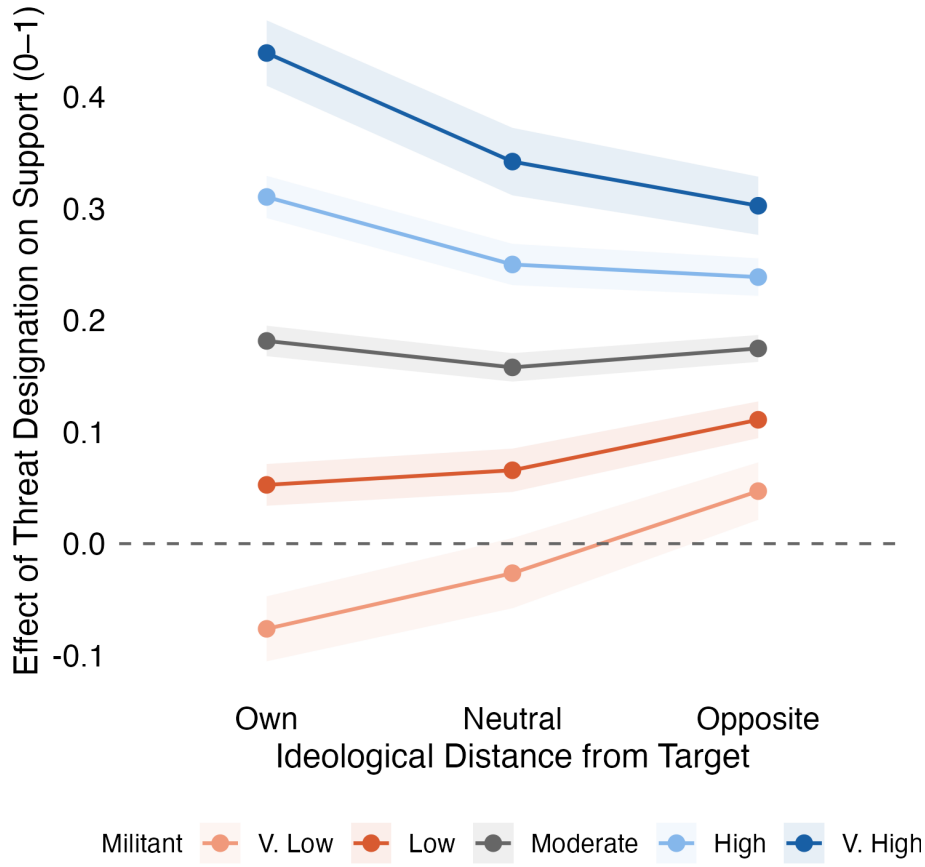
Effect of Militancy Across Groups



Threat Designation Effect over Id. Distance & Militancy



(a) Linear LR-Distance.



(b) Cat. LR-Distance..